

Diploma in Leadership & Management

Stress management for the workplace



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Lesson outcomes

The student will be able to understand the fundamentals of stress management. Students will be able to understand the approaches to take when it comes to dealing with their own stress and giving their team the tools to deal with stress. Student will have a clear idea of the impact that stress has on each person.

Introduction

Stress has such an impact of our life's and a lot of time it's not really addressed or managed. As managers and leaders, you have such a responsibility towards the company, clients, and employees. All of this pressure can lead to stress. There are various tools and approaches to take when it comes to managing stress. We're going to explore exercises and worksheets to complete and that you can share with your team.

Key reading materials:

- <https://www.westvalley.com/resources/employer-resources/top-five-best-stress-management-tips-for-managers>
- <https://inside.6q.io/reduce-stress-in-the-workplace/>
- <https://www.mayoclinic.org/healthy-lifestyle/stress-management/in-depth/stress-relief/art-20044476>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RcGyVTAoXEU>

Stress management tips:

Please note that all of the worksheets are provided and guided by TherapistAid.com

Self-care means taking time to do things you enjoy. Usually, self-care involves everyday activities that you find relaxing, fun, or energizing. These activities could be as simple as reading a book, or as big as taking a vacation.

Self-care also means taking care of yourself. This means eating regular meals, getting enough sleep, caring for personal hygiene, and anything else that maintains good health.

Make self-care a priority. There will always be other things to do, but don't let these interrupt the time you set aside for self-care. Self-care should be given the same importance as other responsibilities.

Set specific self-care goals. It's difficult to follow through with vague goals, such as "I will take more time for self-care". Instead, try something specific, such as "I will walk for 30 minutes every evening after dinner".

Make self-care a habit. Just like eating one apple doesn't eliminate health problems, using self-care just once won't have much effect on reducing stress. Choose activities that you can do often, and that you will stick with.

Set boundaries to protect your self-care. You don't need a major obligation to say "no" to others—your self-care is reason enough. Remind yourself that your needs are as important as anyone else's.

A few minutes of self-care is better than no self-care. Set an alarm reminding you to take regular breaks, even if it's just a walk around the block, or an uninterrupted snack. Oftentimes, stepping away will energize you to work more efficiently when you return.

Unhealthy activities don't count as self-care. Substance use, over-eating, and other unhealthy behaviors might hide uncomfortable emotions temporarily, but they cause more problems in the long run.

Keep up with self-care, even when you're feeling good. Doing so will keep you in a healthy routine. Plus, self-care might be part of the reason why you're feeling good!

Stress exploration:

Factors that Contribute to Stress

Describe your biggest stressors in each of the following categories and rate them on a scale of 1-10, where 1 is “a little stressful” and 10 is “extremely stressful.”

Daily hassles

Common annoyances or strains of daily life. Examples: traffic, chores, work problems, lack of sleep, homework, limited free time, argument with partner.

Item	Rating

Life Circumstances

Permanent or long-term circumstances that make life more difficult. Examples: poverty or financial problems, disability, chronic illness, conflictual relationships, values that conflict with culture, discrimination, job dissatisfaction, living somewhere unsafe

Item	Rating

Factors that Protect Against Stress

Describe the things in your life that counteract stress.

Daily Uplifts

Positive experiences that make you happy. Examples: eating a good meal, spending time with friends, leisure activities, spending time in nature

Healthy Coping Strategies

Positive actions that help to reduce or manage stress and other uncomfortable emotions. Examples: exercise, talking about problems, self-care, journaling, relaxation techniques

Protective Factors

Individual characteristics or life circumstances that protect you from stress. Examples: financial stability, good physical health, supportive family, motivation to succeed, education

Healthy and unhealthy coping strategies:

Coping strategies are actions we take--consciously or unconsciously--to deal with stress, problems, or uncomfortable emotions. Unhealthy coping strategies tend to feel good in the moment, but have long-term negative consequences. Healthy coping strategies may not provide instant gratification, but they lead to long-lasting positive outcomes.

Examples of unhealthy coping strategies:	Examples of healthy coping strategies:
• Drug or alcohol use • Overeating • Procrastination • Sleeping too much or too little • Social withdrawal • Self-harm • Aggression	• Exercise • Talking about your problem • Healthy eating • Seeking professional help • Relaxation techniques (e.g. deep breathing) • Using social support • Problem-solving techniques

Example scenarios

Noelle has a research paper due in one of her classes. Because the paper will require so much work, Noelle feels anxious every time she thinks about it. When Noelle distracts herself with other activities, she feels better. Noelle uses the coping strategy of procrastination to avoid her feelings of anxiety. This helps her feel better now, but will cause problems in the long run.

Juan feels jealous whenever his wife spends time with her friends. To control the situation, Juan uses insults to put down his wife’s friends, and he demands that his wife stay home. When Juan’s wife caves to his demands, he feels a sense of relief. Juan uses the coping strategy of aggression to avoid the discomfort of jealousy.

Rebecca is angry about being passed over for a promotion at work. Rather than discussing the situation with her boss and trying to improve her work performance, she holds onto her anger. Rebecca has learned to manage her anger by drinking alcohol. Drinking numbs Rebecca’s anger temporarily, but the problems at work remain unresolved.

Scenario discussion questions

- What consequences might result from this individual's unhealthy coping strategy?
- What healthy coping strategies could be helpful for the individual?
- What barriers might be preventing the individual from using healthy coping strategies?

Describe a problem you are currently dealing with:

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My unhealthy coping strategies:

Consequences of unhealthy coping strategies:

1.

2.

Healthy coping strategies I use, or could use:

Expected outcomes of healthy coping strategies:

Barriers to using healthy coping strategies:

1.

2.

3.

References

- [TherapistAid.com](https://therapistaid.com)